Tree Ensembles: Random Forests & Boosted Trees

ECON 8310: Business Forecasting — Lecture 5

Department of Economics

University of Nebraska at Omaha

October 16, 2026

Lecture Outline

1. From Single Trees to Ensembles
2. Bagging: Bootstrap Aggregating
3. Random Forests: Decorrelating the Trees
4. Feature Importance and Interpretation
5. Gradient Boosting
6. XGBoost
7. Key Takeaways and Roadmap

From Single Trees to Ensembles

Averaging many imperfect models can outperform any single model.

The Wisdom of Crowds

A single expert can be wrong. Average many *independent* estimates and the errors tend to cancel.

> **Classic Example: Guessing the Ox's Weight**
>
> At a 1907 county fair, 800 people guessed the weight of an ox. No individual was very accurate — but the **average of all 800 guesses** came within one pound of the true weight.

Models work the same way. One tree is unstable, Lecture 4's closing complaint. Average many trees fitted to different versions of the data and the noise largely cancels while the signal survives.

Ensembles work because independent errors cancel. The more independent the trees, the more averaging removes: the difference between bagging and random forests turns on that word.

Bagging: Bootstrap Aggregating

Train many trees on bootstrap samples; average their predictions.

Bagging: The Big Idea

Problem from Lecture 4: one tree has high variance. **Bagging** (Breiman 1996) averages it away:

1. Draw B **bootstrap samples** (with replacement, the same size as the data)
2. Fit one deep decision tree to each
3. **Average** the B predictions: $\hat{y}_{\text{bag}} = \frac{1}{B}\sum_{b=1}^{B} \hat{f}^{(b)}(\mathbf{x})$

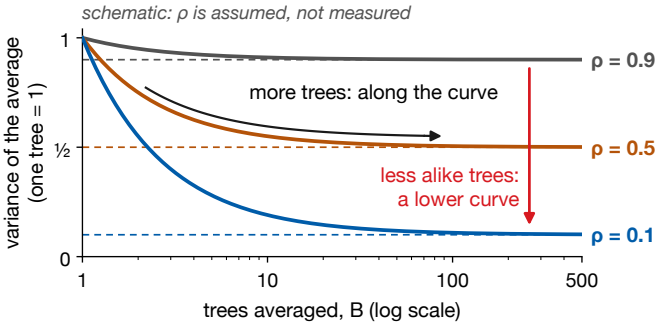
Why it works, and where it stops. With σ^2 one tree's variance and ρ the correlation between two trees' predictions,

$$\text{Var}(\bar{f}) = \rho\sigma^2 + \frac{1-\rho}{B}\sigma^2.$$

More trees shrink the second term; the first never moves.

More Trees, or Less Alike Trees

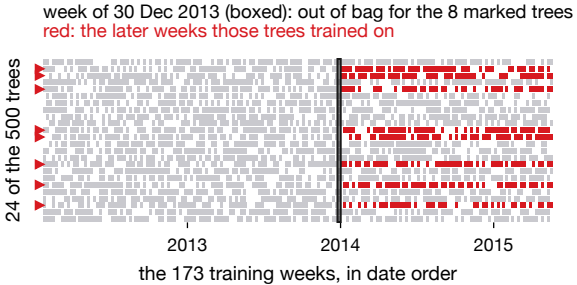
Divide by σ^2 and each ρ draws its own curve, flattening onto a floor at ρ:



Growing more trees only slides you along a curve. **The floor is set by how alike the trees are**, not by how many you grow: to get below it, make them less alike.

Out-of-Bag (OOB) Error: Free Cross-Validation

A bootstrap sample holds about **63%** of the distinct rows. Score each row with only the trees that never saw it (`oob_score=True`): no refitting. But look at who scores it:



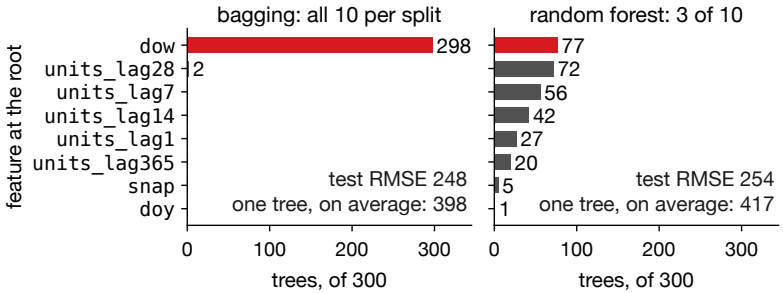
On a time series it is not a forecast test. The trees that score a week trained on about 64% of the weeks after it: OOB fills gaps. Use walk-forward CV.

Random Forests: Decorrelating the Trees

Restrict each split to a random subset of features so trees are less alike.

The Problem Bagging Does Not Fully Solve

If one feature dominates (`dow` daily, the four-week lag weekly), nearly every bagged tree splits on it first and ρ stays high. **The random forest fix** (Breiman 2001): at each split, consider only a random $m < p$ of the features.



Lab 5, 300 trees each. The fix spreads the roots, and its trees average better (417 to 254, against 398 to 248), but they start worse: with one dominant feature among ten, `sqrt` loses.

Random Forest Hyperparameters

Parameter	sklearn name	Default	Effect
Number of trees	`n_estimators`	100	More = lower variance; plateaus ∼500
Max features/split	`max_features`	`1.0` (all)	Lower = more decorrelated
Max depth	`max_depth`	None	Limit only to reduce memory
Min samples/leaf	`min_samples_leaf`	1	Higher = smoother predictions
OOB score	`oob_score`	False	`True` gives a free CV estimate

The default is plain bagging. scikit-learn's regressor considers every feature at every split; `'sqrt'` is the classifier's default. So set `max_features` yourself: it is the dial for ρ, and the only one that really needs tuning. Start with `n_estimators`=500, `min_samples_leaf`=5.

Set `random_state=42`: a forest is random twice over, in the bootstrap samples and in the feature subsets.

Feature Importance and Interpretation

Which predictors matter most? RF gives a data-driven answer.

Random Forest Feature Importance (Molnar 2022)

Mean Decrease in Impurity (MDI)

For each feature j, average the total reduction in node impurity across every split on j, weighted by the fraction of observations reaching that node. Normalize to sum to 1.

Feature (CA_1 FOODS, weekly)	Importance
units_lag4	0.28
units_lag1	0.21
snap_days	0.17
units_lag52	0.15
units_lag2	0.09
units_lag3	0.06

From the next slide's forest; Lecture 4's single tree gave the four-week lag 0.62. A screening device only: **MDI is biased** toward features with many split points.
`permutation_importance` (shuffle a column, measure the damage) is the honest alternative.

Random Forest in Python

sklearn Code Template

```
from sklearn.ensemble import RandomForestRegressor
rf = RandomForestRegressor(n_estimators=500, max_features='sqrt',
min_samples_leaf=5, oob_score=True, random_state=42).fit(X_tr, y_tr)
print(rf.oob_score_);  importances = rf.feature_importances_
```

Model (CA_1 FOODS, 52-week test)	Test RMSE
Seasonal naïve	1,660
Single deep tree	1,456
Random Forest	**1,115**

The forest cuts RMSE by **23%** against a single deep tree. Both tree models beat the seasonal naive benchmark, the first in this course to do so on this series.

What changed is not a better model of the series but a richer feature set — lags, price, and SNAP days are information ETS and ARIMA never had.

Gradient Boosting

Instead of averaging independent trees, fit each new tree to the errors of all previous trees.

Boosting vs. Bagging: The Core Difference

Bagging (Random Forest):

- Trees built **in parallel**
- Each tree predicts y
- Averaging cuts *variance*
- More trees never cut bias

Boosting:

- Trees built **in sequence**
- Each fits the *errors* so far
- Cuts *bias* as well
- Overfits if trees are too deep or too many

The intuition. Forecast 1 says \$50,000 against an actual \$60,000; forecast 2 predicts the *error*, +\$10,000, and the sum is right. Averaging never fixes a bias like that.

The Gradient Boosting Algorithm

Gradient Boosting (squared-error loss)

Initialize $F_0(\mathbf{x}) = \bar{y}$. For $b = 1, \ldots, B$:

1. Compute residuals: $r_i^{(b)} = y_i - F_{b-1}(\mathbf{x}_i)$
2. Fit a shallow tree T_b to $\{(\mathbf{x}_i, r_i^{(b)})\}$
3. Update: $F_b = F_{b-1} + \eta T_b$

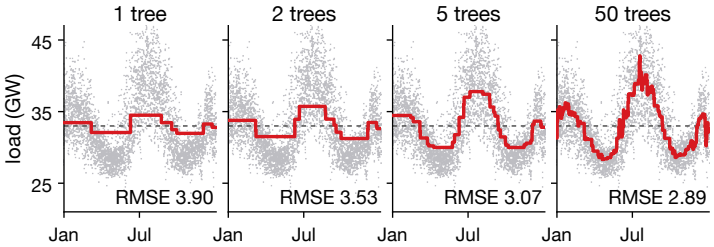
Final prediction: $\hat{y} = F_B(\mathbf{x})$

Trees are **shallow** (depth 3 to 6): each captures a little of what remains.

The learning rate η is the main dial: 0.01–0.1 is slow and robust, above 0.3 risks overshooting. Use a small η, many trees and **early stopping**, or boosting fits your noise.

Boosting, Tree by Tree

The algorithm on one feature, so the fit can be drawn: weekday electricity load against day of the year (Lecture 3's data). Depth-3 trees, $\eta = 0.3$, starting from the mean (dashed):



Each tree fits what the curve still misses, so the year's W emerges a piece at a time. By 50 trees the training RMSE is 2.89 GW, against 2.86 for the best any day-of-year curve can do: what remains is noise this feature cannot explain.

XGBoost

Three improvements over vanilla boosting: second-order optimization, explicit regularization, and column subsampling.

XGBoost: Three Advances (Chen and Guestrin 2016)

1. **Newton step.** Uses the loss's curvature as well as its slope. For squared error the curvature is constant, so this is the ordinary residual fit; it matters for log-loss or Poisson.
2. **Explicit regularization.** Penalties on leaf count and leaf size, inside the objective.
3. **Column subsampling**, borrowed from random forests.

`reg_lambda` is Ridge and `reg_alpha` is LASSO, on leaf weights (next week). `gamma` is a price per leaf, like Lecture 4's `ccp_alpha`.

XGBoost dominated Kaggle tabular competitions in 2014–2018.

XGBoost: Key Hyperparameters

Parameter	XGB name	Typical	Effect
Number of trees	`n_estimators`	500–2000	More + small η = better (use early stopping)
Learning rate	`learning_rate`	0.01–0.1	Smaller = more robust; needs more trees
Tree depth	`max_depth`	3–6	Shallow preferred; depth >6 risks overfit
Row subsample	`subsample`	0.7–0.9	Fraction of training rows per tree
Col. subsample	`colsample_bytree`	0.7–0.9	Feature fraction per tree (like RF)
L2 leaf penalty	`reg_lambda`	1	Ridge on leaf weights; stabilizes

Practical starting point: `learning_rate=0.05`, `max_depth=4`, `n_estimators=1000` with early stopping on validation RMSE. Tune `max_depth` and `subsample` via `TimeSeriesSplit`.

XGBoost in Python

Code Template

```
model = xgb.XGBRegressor(n_estimators=1000, learning_rate=0.05,
max_depth=4, subsample=0.8, colsample_bytree=0.8,
early_stopping_rounds=50, random_state=42)
model.fit(X_train, y_train, eval_set=[(X_val, y_val)], verbose=False)
```

`eval_set` is what makes `early_stopping_rounds` work: XGBoost watches validation RMSE and halts when it stops improving, which is how you get away with setting `n_estimators` far higher than you need.

The validation set must respect time. Build it with `TimeSeriesSplit` and hold out the final stretch as a true test set.

On macOS `xgboost` also needs OpenMP: `brew install libomp`, or the import fails.

Key Takeaways and Roadmap

Bagging reduces variance; boosting reduces bias. Together they cover most of what tabular forecasting needs.

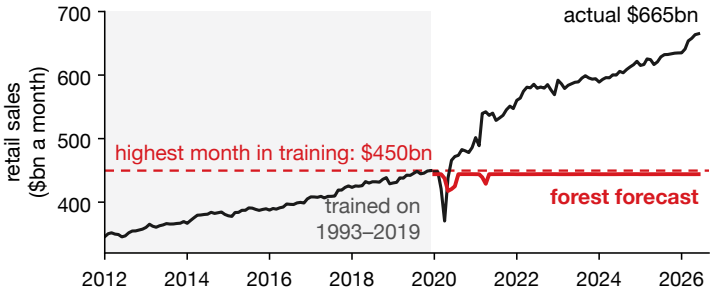
Tree Methods: Which One When

Method	Training	Interpretable	Tuning	Accuracy
Decision Tree	Single tree	High	Low	Baseline
Random Forest	Parallel (B trees)	Medium	Low	Good
XGBoost	Sequential (B trees)	Low	Higher	Best

Random Forest is the better default: robust, almost no tuning, OOB error for free. **Move to XGBoost** when you can afford to tune and need the last few points — and budget for that tuning, because an untuned XGBoost often loses to a default forest.

Why No Tree Can Extrapolate

A forest's prediction is a weighted average of training targets, so it can never leave [training min, training max]. A forest trained on US retail sales through 2019, then given each later month's true lags:



It never forecasts above $450bn; by mid-2026 sales are $665bn. Boosted trees go flat beyond their last split too. On a trending series, keep a model that can extrapolate.

Lecture 5: Key Takeaways

1. **Ensembles** work because independent errors cancel.
2. **Bagging** averages bootstrap trees; variance floors at $\rho\sigma^2$.
3. **Random forests** cut ρ by sampling features at each split — when no single feature dominates.
4. **OOB error** is free, but on a time series it scores gaps, not forecasts.
5. **Boosting** fits each tree to the errors so far: it attacks bias.
6. No tree can **extrapolate** beyond the training range.
7. Tune with `TimeSeriesSplit`; pair boosting with **early stopping**.

Next: Regularization & Model Selection — choosing among many predictors by shrinking coefficients rather than counting them.

References I

- Breiman, Leo (1996). "Bagging Predictors". In: *Machine Learning* 24.2, pp. 123–140.
- — (2001). "Random Forests". In: *Machine Learning* 45.1, pp. 5–32.
- Chen, Tianqi and Carlos Guestrin (2016). "XGBoost: A Scalable Tree Boosting System". In: *Proceedings of the 22nd ACM SIGKDD International Conference on Knowledge Discovery and Data Mining*, pp. 785–794.
- Molnar, Christoph (2022). *Interpretable Machine Learning: A Guide for Making Black Box Models Explainable*. 2nd. Open access. URL: https://christophm.github.io/interpretable-ml-book/.